

****Us and Privacy, Scorza: Our Duties and the Right of Young People to a Safer Web****
Intervention by Guido Scorza, member of the Guarantor for the protection of personal data
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"Chronicle and calendar, in recent weeks, have compelled us to reflect on the relationship between young people and violence, particularly gender violence. The events in Palermo and Caivano, involving young and very young individuals, victims and perpetrators of group rapes meticulously recorded on smartphones, often with the intention—sometimes realized—of spreading the images online, to violate the unfortunate victims a second time. The femicide of Giulia Cecchettin, no longer a minor but still a girl, at the hands of another boy, albeit also no longer a minor, her ex-boyfriend. Then, the World Day for the Rights of the Child and Adolescents celebrated on November 20, with, among other initiatives, the research presented by Telefono Azzurro and Doxa at the CNEL, the National Council of Economy and Labor, to emphasize how the dependency relationship between young people and social media has never been so tight. Finally, but only to pause on the events that have most evidently marked a calendar that seems almost to have wanted to suggest a path of reflection that has been less traversed than necessary, on November 25, the World Day for the Elimination of Violence Against Women, felt this year in our country more than in the past precisely due to the dramatic emotions that have clung to our skin and minds following the news of Giulia's murder.

****The Online Life of Young People****

Facts, only and exclusively facts, that we can choose to let wash over us and be erased by time, or not. If we opt for the latter, it is wise to start with the numbers. So here are some. A first number is recently provided by the aforementioned research by Telefono Azzurro and Doxa just presented at the CNEL: 41% of boys aged 12 to 18 report spending between two and three hours online each day, while 17% spend more than six hours online daily, and, importantly, 44% of them, faced with the idea of spending a week—not eternity—without social media would feel lost, anxious, or agitated, while only 10% would feel free and happy. The almost totality of the children interviewed—this is another piece of data that should make us reflect and remind us, as adults, of our responsibilities—have no doubts about the fact that social media can cause addiction. 93% of respondents think so. Yet, such awareness is not enough to lead them to adopt a more cautious attitude in their use of social media, essentially for three reasons: they are a way to relax, pass the time, combat boredom, and stay in touch with friends and—however absurd it may seem—family.

****The Three Alarm Fronts****

Among the many numbers useful in indicating the way forward, there are three others that deserve special mention: 34% report having encountered violent content online, 21% have come across sexually explicit content without intending to, and 17% have been contacted by adult strangers. The useful summary to continue the reasoning is simple: young people spend a significant part of their day online, they literally and consciously depend on social media, and they frequently encounter content with which they are ill-equipped to engage. Obviously, from here to jumping to the easy conclusion that social media are responsible for so much violence, including gender violence, among young people, is a long step; however, one cannot deny the existence of a strong relationship at least as significant as that which existed in the past between pervasive television models and subcultures and gender violence, and not only that. In fact, it is probably more significant for different reasons. A couple, perhaps, more important than others.

The first: yesterday, the television bombardment was from one to many, and therefore its effectiveness was relative; it had more impact on some and less on others, while today, aided by profiling, each person is presented with different content in a way, at a place, and at a time that is likely to make a greater impression on the recipient's mind.

The second: yesterday, as adults, we could try to guide the media diet of young people; the TV would be turned off at a certain hour, certain programs would be "forbidden," and others would be suggested, while today everything is accessible to everyone, anytime and anywhere, and, worse still, always aided by profiling, every propensity, inclination, desire, or even unexpressed temptation is used to build authentic media bubbles, with the consequence that if one succumbs to certain content a couple of

times, one risks seeing it saturate their bubble forever.

****Personal Data Given Up and the "Media Bubble"****

The blame lies with the personal data that we all—though younger individuals even more lightly—give up in exchange for the right to use digital services and platforms that ultimately become the exclusive directors of our media diet, for better or worse. It is an unsustainable situation that, as adults, we cannot tolerate or accept with resignation because we have a duty towards young people: we must guarantee them the right not to have to choose between using digital technology with its extraordinary opportunities or doing without it, withdrawing from the risk that it becomes an inspiration for behaviors and ways of living capable of destroying them. We owe young people a safe digital environment, and it is up to us to find the way to guarantee it. It would be a mistake to claim certainty about the solution, but at the same time, it would be a mistake to doubt that it can be found.

find without going through education on the use of media at school as well as at home, which undoubtedly represents a necessary but not sufficient condition to hope that digital technology can guide the younger generation towards a future better than ours, from which all violence, starting with gender-based violence, is kept as far away as possible.